

You Only Pick Your Mates

The principle. A village cricket captain in Somerset is told at the bar that he only picks his mates. He has Code Overlord build him an app he calls Whosanygood, which ranks every man who has played for the club and picks the best eleven, fairly, on the numbers. It picks them perfectly, and he does not fancy any of them. Because he asked for fair, every exception he wants has to go in as a rule for everybody, and the app obeys every rule he writes, until the best eleven it can find is exactly his mates, and the league makes every club in Somerset use it.

Why it is funny. The engine is a man overruling a machine that is right every time, one tiny, deeply personal reason at a time, while insisting the whole thing is fair. Each reason is a little story of its own, and because every rule has to go for everybody, each one catches somebody he did not mean. The software never fails, and he never once notices what he is doing.

Ray Aldridge, sixty-seven, captain for forty years, has a folding chair with RAY on it in electrical tape. In April 2027, Leon, not picked again, said something at the bar.

"He says to me, you only pick your mates." A pause. "So I asked Code Overlord for an app. Every man who's played for us, ranked. Best eleven." A pause. "Fair."

He typed that in, and by Tuesday it was built.

He called it Whosanygood.

"That's what I asked it."

First thing it said: Baz, picked every week for thirty years, hasn't scored since the London Olympics.

"Did you tell Baz?"

"He's my lift."

Then it picked the best eleven. Top of it was Leon.

"I looked down it. I didn't fancy none of them."

"So you played them?"

A very long pause. "We're never going to be professionals."

But he'd told the club the app picks now, so he couldn't just drop them. And he'd told it fair.

"So I had Code Overlord let me take some out. It won't do names. You got to give it a rule, and a rule goes for everybody."

It checks every man against the club WhatsApp. Number two in the eleven was Jim.

"Couch to 5K. Fell over a cat." A pause. "It were asleep."

NOBODY WHO HAS FALLEN OVER A CAT. It took out Jim. And two others.

"It's more common than you'd think."

Each time, it put the next best in.

"Gavin's a dead body in a film. In a ditch." A pause. "You can see him breathing."

NOBODY WHO HAS PLAYED A DEAD BODY. It took out Gavin, and his dad.

"Same film?"

"Same ditch."

"Nigel. Best bat in the county. Reverses into parking spaces."

NOBODY WHO REVERSES INTO A SPACE. It took out Nigel. And Baz.

"So I got Code Overlord to put in an exception."

UNLESS THERE IS SOMEBODY IN THE CAR WITH HIM.

"Is there always somebody in the car with Baz?"

"Me." A pause. "He's my lift."

So Nigel started bringing his nan.

"So I put in, unless the passenger's sixty-seven."

"You're sixty-seven."

"It's an age."

Nigel, in the car park, with his nan:

"Tell Ray he can shove his chair up his [BLEEP]."

His nan: "Unfolded."

Next in, Kieran, won a ham in the raffle and did a speech.

"Nobody asked him. He thanked his mum." A pause. "It were a small ham."

NOBODY WHO HAS DONE A SPEECH NOBODY ASKED FOR.

Which left Leon.

"Leon's never fell over nothing." A pause. "Took me a fortnight."

NOBODY WHO HAS SAID THE CAPTAIN ONLY PICKS HIS MATES.

Thursday it posted the side. WHOSANYGOOD.COM.

"Who was on it?"

"Me. Baz. The lads." A pause. "Same as last Saturday."

"How many rules did it take?"

"Hundred and six." A pause. "The whole of cricket's only got forty-two."

Leon went to the league. Ray's on the committee. He left the room and made the tea.

"Cleanest selection in Somerset," said the secretary. "Not one name in it. Every club's having it."

"So I had Code Overlord open it up for them."

With one rule from the league: NOBODY WHO HAS COMPLAINED TO THE LEAGUE.

"Whose idea was that?"

"Mine." A pause. "I shouted it through from the kitchen."

Leon can't play anywhere now. He does the buffet.

In September the league gave Ray the Fair Play Cup.

"They give you a cup." A pause. "You don't wait to be asked." "I thanked Code Overlord." A pause. "And my mum."

Leon filmed the speech and put it on the WhatsApp.

Thursday: RAY ALDRIDGE. NOT SELECTED. NOBODY WHO HAS DONE A SPEECH NOBODY ASKED FOR.

He reads it in his chair.

"Has Whosanygood ever been wrong?"

A long pause. "Never been wrong once."

Into his phone:

"Unless his name's on the chair."

In the car park, Nigel's nan reads it on the WhatsApp.

"Unfolded." A pause. "With him sat in it."

Card. Nothing after it.

What a Code Overlord user sees, and nobody else does. One plain sentence sent literally, and a window opening under it for every season in the scorebooks. A persona he wrote whose whole operating instructions are one word, "Fair", which is why the app will take a rule and never a name, and why every exception he asks for comes back as a rule. The app wired to the club WhatsApp, reading back to the start. Rules said into a phone at the bar and landing in a session on the laptop at home. A job on a cadence, every Thursday at nine, that re-picks the side and posts it whether anyone is watching or not. One agent summoning one more for every club when the league takes it. Whosanygood is the app his agents built. Code Overlord is the workshop.

Accent. The whole cast is Somerset, West Country: Ray, the interviewer, Leon, Nigel and his nan, and the league secretary. Whosanygood's rules, in capitals, are the only thing in it that is not. Never spell it: it lives in the grammar and the word order, "he says to me", "I didn't fancy none of them", "it were asleep", "Leon's never fell over nothing", "it were a small ham", "they give you a cup".

Three things to decide. First, the number's second half: "The whole of cricket's only got forty-two" is recommended, because three of the five comedians said it is right where it is and a teenager can follow it; Jimmy Carr wants "God managed with ten", a bigger swing; say "God" to swap. Second, the league: the

committee and the kitchen are in, recommended, because they finish Leon off and say why every club has the rule; the long version also has another captain doing rules with his mother beside him ("Nobody my mum don't like." "And the tall one."), which Peter Kay and Steve Coogan would keep instead; it adds about six seconds; say "mother" to put it in. Third, who films Ray's speech: Leon, recommended, because Leon is the one he dropped; Kay's alternative is Baz, "He were proud of me"; say "Baz" to swap.

Condensed from a longer version with fifteen exceptions, reworked through two comedians' panels (Larry David, Steve Coogan, Jimmy Carr, Peter Kay, Armando Iannucci); the long version is kept.